

So how did Leonardo begin his most famous painting? Like many artists of his time, he chose a wood backing for smaller paintings, even though canvas was now available. To paint the *Mona Lisa*, he used poplar wood.

The choice of paint itself was also important. Many Italian painters used tempera, a water-based paint that gave a flat finish and dried quickly. Leonardo liked to use a technique called *sfumato* (from the Italian word for smoke), in which the tones and colors were gradually blended together. To achieve this effect, he needed more time for his brushstrokes than tempera allowed. Slow-drying oil paint gave him this extra time.

PAINTING TECHNIQUE

One significant aspect of Leonardo's approach to painting was his use of soft, muted colors. His images, whether of people or landscapes, never had harsh edges or bold colors that sharply contrasted with one another. Leonardo always aimed for an effect where the colors almost flowed into one another, creating a seamless whole that extended from one end of the painting to the other.